

5

Action

“If you can’t count it, it didn’t happen!”

I was one of thirty novice organizers packed into a hot, converted tract house living room. Collectively, we had been charged with organizing one thousand farmworkers. Our goal? To win the first union representation election in the history of California agriculture.

The Schenley victory opened the way to a second boycott: the Tree Sweet products of the giant DiGiorgio Fruit Corporation. This, as well as Governor Brown’s intervention, moved DiGiorgio to agree to a secret ballot election. The 1.2-million-strong Teamsters Union had allied with the DiGiorgio Fruit Corporation to crush the independent farmworkers’ union, then known as the NFWA, led by Cesar Chavez and largely made up of workers of color. This was Delano, California, late August 1966. The table grape harvest was at its peak, and we had thirty days to go until the vote. Every day, we were organizing workers who faced aggressive foremen, threatening bosses, and Teamster thugs.

Each organizer was responsible for organizing a specific number of workers, recruiting a specific number of leaders, and getting support commitments from a specific number of voters—the number of votes we needed to win. We kept track of how many people we tried to get to a meeting and how many came. We asked why those who didn’t come, didn’t, and why those who did, did. We tracked each worker on a three-by-five file card in a small metal file box.

Cesar had recruited organizer Fred Ross to train us as he had trained Cesar in the 1950s. In charge of the campaign, Fred went person by person. “What are your numbers? Why *those* numbers? What did you learn?” As Fred posted them on the wall for all to see, he asked why good was good, why bad was bad, and what patterns we saw across the whole. It wasn’t only about accountability. It was about learning. And if a report included an “I guess” or “it seems,” or “about,” it was close to a mortal sin. In this way, what could

feel like interrogation turned into inquiry: we learned what was working and what wasn't, who was reliable and who wasn't, and how to adapt strategy and tactics given the ever-changing reality of a campaign in which workers had to stand up to threats, firings, and worse.

We understood that we win elections by securing—and delivering—votes. We secure votes by getting commitments. We get commitments by learning each worker's story. God, they say (or the devil), is in the details. Love for the details is a prerequisite for excellence in any craft, including that of organizing.

In the end we won the election: 530 NFWA, 331 Teamsters, 7 No Union.

This approach didn't come easily to me. I had never experienced this intense discipline before my work with the NFWA. I didn't like it. I was cool. I'd earned my chops in Mississippi, where we didn't have to show up for so many meetings, especially right on time, nor did we have to do all this counting. I found an ally in Marcos Munoz, a streetwise farmworker organizer who had learned to survive by knowing a thing or two, even if that didn't include reading and writing. He had no use for Fred's rules either. After a meeting that we didn't want to go to—and boy, had we shown it—Fred came over to us: "Cesar would like to talk with you." Oops. The principal's office?

We sat down with Cesar and Fred. You both have lots of potential, Cesar told us, and you're welcome to stay. "But if you do decide to stay, be clear. Fred is in charge. Fred's rules apply. They apply to everyone. If not, no hard feelings, just good luck, and goodbye."

We decided to stay.

That's when I began to learn organizing as a craft. A few years later, I was managing an organizer who kept losing three-by-five cards. "Those aren't cards you're losing," I explained, "they're people. Each one matters." It helped. Perhaps this was the beginning of what I now call "evidence-based organizing"!

Many years later, I was training a youthful cohort of organizers in the 2003/4 New Hampshire campaign for Democratic presidential candidate Howard Dean. The same age I had been when I learned to count, so did they. A few years later, when I was training organizers in the 2008 Obama campaign, our digital tools had sure improved from the three-by-five cards and the yellow legal pads. But it still came down to the same thing: people working with people . . . again . . . and again . . . and counting . . . and counting . . . and learning . . . and learning. And most critically, knowing what exactly you are

counting and why! It's too easy to fall into the trap of the drunk who lost his car keys where his car was parked—a block away from the streetlight under which he was looking for them. When asked why he was searching there, he responded, "It's where the light is."

We have been learning how organizing works. We learned how building relationships lays a foundation for storytelling, the *heart* work, which, in turn, lays a foundation for strategizing, the *head* work, which, in turn, creates a foundation for action, the *hands* work. It is this action work that creates real change. Change happens on the ground, or it doesn't happen.

In this chapter, I focus on action: mobilizing and deploying resources to create real change—and to grow more resources to deploy. Because organizing is about empowering people, the most valuable and abundant resources are those held by people as people: our time, our bodies, our imaginations, and our agency—the capacity to choose, to say no, or to say yes. The challenge then is to mobilize these individual resources and deploy them as collective power. Organizers of the Montgomery Bus Boycott mobilized the individual resource of feet and deployed them collectively as a boycott. Union members contribute dues that can be deployed as hired staff or a strike fund. They can also deploy their time as a strike.

One of the major organizing challenges we face today is the ever-greater reliance on financial resources that come from outside one's constituency rather than on resources from within one's constituency. Today, "Who will fund it?" is often the first question people ask when it comes to almost anything, including organizing. But a focus on fundraising as the first question ("enabling condition") corrupts the craft of organizing, which leads with people as the primary source of power. Instead, too often, power is conditioned on the ability to access the funds of wealthy donors who have colonized civil society with projects that depend on their largesse.¹ This outsized influence of donors shifts the locus of accountability from one's people to one's funders, further eroding the power of people at the heart of organizing.

This chapter discusses how organizers can—and must—meet this challenge, not only to win this or that campaign, but to get democracy itself on track. Motivating people to commit to a shared purpose, turning our commitments into collective action, and turning collective action into power is how we win a campaign to improve a school, elect a president, or fight climate change.

What Is Action?

Action is making it happen on the ground (or online): votes in the ballot box, people at the rally, a union contract signed, a wealth tax passed, schools funded well, housing built, access to health care expanded, the unjustly convicted released, the minimum wage raised, coal power banned, and so on.

Action is about mobilizing and deploying resources. Resource *mobilization* refers to the process of gathering resources, often from individuals. Resource *deployment* refers to the process of spending (or investing) those resources, often collectively. The way resources are mobilized affects how they can be deployed, and the way they are deployed affects how they can be mobilized, as shown in Figure 5.1.

A useful way to think about resources is Albert Hirschman's distinction between economic resources and moral resources.² Economic resources deplete with use: spend fifty dollars out of the one hundred dollars that you have, and you'll only have fifty dollars. But moral resources *grow* with use: commitment generates more commitment, trust generates more trust, learning generates more learning, and skill generates more skill.

Because organizers usually must rely on some combination of moral and economic resources, recruiting people and raising money can be built into every activity. In the UFW, we never went anywhere without a can and clipboard. We used both—the can to collect money and the clipboard to sign

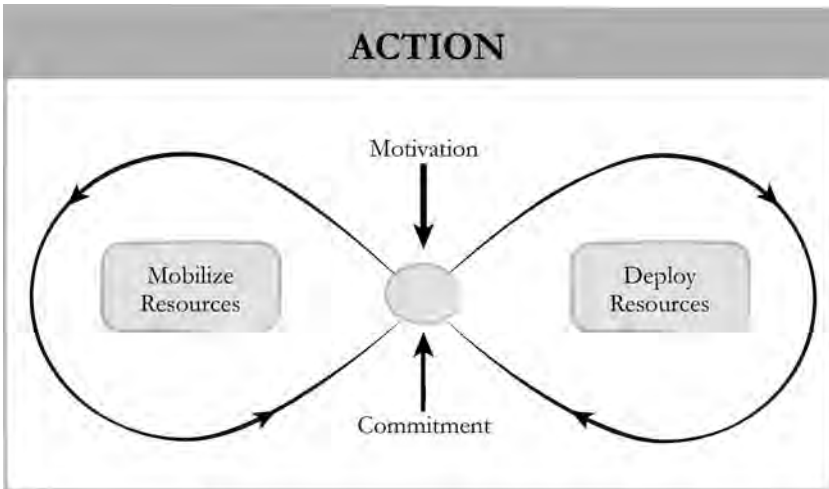


Figure 5.1 Action. Source: Steve Downer of the Difference

up volunteers—very extensively on the streets of Manhattan. One day I was walking along, holding a “Boycott Lettuce” sign in one hand and a cup of coffee in the other. Someone passing by said, “I’m with you,” and tossed a quarter into my coffee cup.

Organizers fighting for change challenge a status quo with far more abundant economic and political resources. So organizers must not only be resourceful, as I describe in my strategy chapter, but they must also rely on their people’s resources. Time, as political scientist Sidney Verba noted, is more widely distributed than money. Tactics that take lots of money—if what you have is lots of people—can severely constrain what you can do. The civil rights movement was resourced fundamentally by the time, commitment, bodies, and courage of its constituency.

When you do need outside money, it matters where that money comes from. The civil rights movement primarily mobilized its financial resources from churches, unions, liberals, four small progressive foundations, and the Voter Education Project, a politically inspired voter registration fund overseen by a team of recognized movement leaders.³ The movement enjoyed substantial moral, practical, and political alignment among its leaders, its constituency, and its financial supporters. Unions and churches generate their economic resources by bringing people together to create nonmarket value: worship, justice, hope, and community. Funding that depends on the patronage of someone who believes that the millions they made by inventing a new widget—or knowing when to buy or sell it—entitles them to govern civil society is quite another matter.

Deciding to focus on one’s constituency is not only about the economics of power. Organizers must develop the capacity of their constituency to lead, strategize, collaborate, and mobilize, not only to generate their own resources but also to practice active democratic citizenship. Outside funding can entrap us in privileging “ownership” over “citizenship”: depending on money-based power rather than people-based power.

Although an organization or campaign can mobilize resources in a variety of ways, its center of gravity rests in one of the quadrants depicted in Figure 5.2. If this is in the Inside/People box, then the center of gravity empowers the constituency, becomes accountable to the constituency, and aligns use of resources to the constituency’s interest. One example of an organization that can operate in this way is a democratic union. On the other hand, if the center of gravity is in the Outside/Money box, the dependency it can disempower the constituency (unless the constituency is outside), become

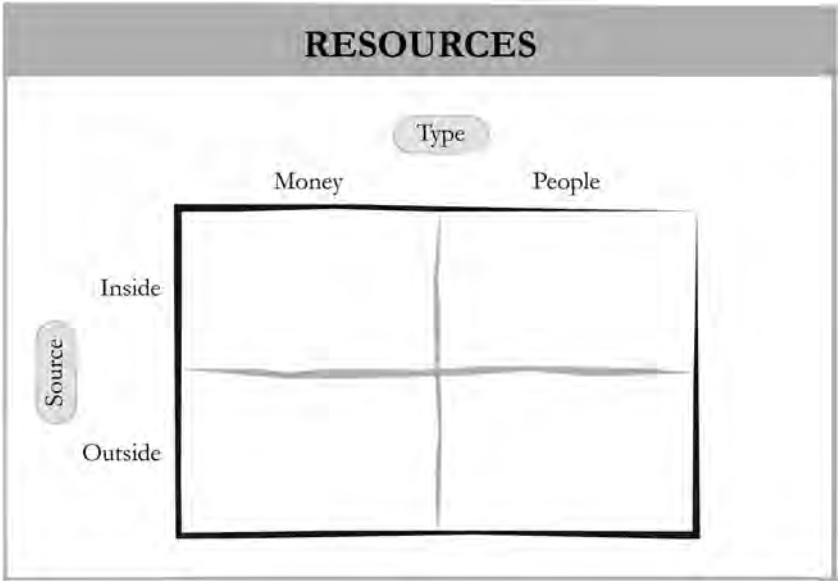


Figure 5.2 Resources. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

accountable to its funders, and limit tactics to those consistent with the interests of its funders.

We need to distinguish the deployment of resources in ways that can generate more resources from ways that simply drain resources mobilized elsewhere. This is one key difference between organizing and mobilizing. In union organizing, for example, the more successful the union, the more members it gets, the larger the dues base, the more leadership it can develop, and the greater its human and financial resources. Similarly, as some community organizations conduct parish renewal work among member churches, their human capacity and financial capacity grow. Grant-based action programs, in contrast, often fail to generate new resources from the work they do, creating a state of perpetual dependency on their funders.

Action is costly in time, effort, and risk. These sacrifices can be widely shared or narrowly held. The more widely shared, the more people have a stake in the outcome. When one or two people do all the sacrificing, they quickly become burned out, while everyone else blames them for whatever goes wrong.

There is no one right relationship between resources and action. But understanding the relationship between resources and action is essential to

making mindful choices about how to structure your campaigns and organization to give them a chance to accomplish their purposes, especially when it comes to empowerment of your constituency.

How Action Works: Motivation and Commitment

The more our core resource is time contributed by our people, the more critical is our capacity to sustain motivation and elicit commitment. Since action is ultimately what organizing is all about—changing the world—it’s remarkable how often we turn the work of action into a test of how committed we are rather than an opportunity to enhance motivation, deepen commitment, and create opportunities for leadership.

Perhaps you’ve found yourself in one of the following three situations:

- You’ve been doing well at recruiting new volunteers, but they only show up to phone bank or to text once or twice and you never hear from them again. How can you keep them coming back?
- You have one person who always runs the tabling operation—or its equivalent—but they’re gone for the year. How do you replace them? And, come to think of it, they and a couple of their close friends are the only ones who ever show up to do tabling. Could this be an opportunity?
- Whether it’s the check-ins for a conference, getting the food lined up for a celebration, or planning for a hearing, why do I always have to tell everyone exactly how to do these jobs when they ought to know how to do them? People just don’t care, do they?

If you’ve encountered any of these situations, you’re struggling with sustaining motivation. You can meet these motivational challenges by designing intrinsically motivational work. When a task is well designed, the people who participate will become more motivated, take more initiative in solving problems, and make a deeper commitment to the work.

When we strategize, we decide on the specific outcomes we need to achieve—and when we need to achieve them—to make the campaign work. For example, our strategy requires that we find ways to give three city council members a greater interest in doing what we want than in ignoring us—or to make it more costly to ignore us than to do what we want. So now we need to organize ourselves to make those outcomes happen.

What specific resources will we ask people to commit: signing a pledge not to eat grapes (for example), signing a petition to the governor, showing up for a meeting, recruiting volunteers for a rally, hosting a house meeting, voting, or something else? A commitment is a specific pledge of the amount of a person's time, money, or action needed to achieve the desired outcome.

It is not whatever a person happens to feel like giving in the moment. When a person says they can't be there for an hour, we may ask, how about half an hour? Can't do that? How about fifteen minutes?

But if it will take an hour for the person to learn what is required, get to work doing it, and they stop before they've gotten good at it, little gets done. What value does this add to our campaign? And what if we need fifty people to show up to a particular meeting to meet a required threshold?

The skill, then, is in matching the needs of your campaign with the motivation of your people. This is the sweet spot for organizing action.

In the above example, only about twenty people ever show up at a city council meeting. So, we've decided that if a delegation of twenty people from each of the three recalcitrant council member's districts showed up, it could be an effective way to kick off our campaign. So how can we organize ourselves to make it happen? What about social media, emails, and texting? These can be useful ways to share information. Will broadcasting an invitation result in twenty people from each district showing up? Not likely. What we need are commitments—commitments we make to each other to be there. So how can I organize this? What if I recruited five people from each district to form a leadership team? And what if each member of the leadership team committed, not only to me but to each other, to commit three more people to join us for a pre-action training session in two weeks? And what if we asked each person, in turn, to make a list of the specific people to whom they would reach out?

Of course, unless people are motivated to fight for the change they need, not much will happen. On the other hand, we too often rely on motivation alone to do the job, without creating the commitment to make it happen—and along the way, launch three leadership teams, working together, to build their own teams. The result, then, is not only sixty people at a council meeting, but new organizational capacity and the new leadership to take it even further—three outcomes, not only one, at best.

So, asking for commitments, protecting them, following up on them, and making good on them is a central function of organizing. Eliciting commitments can be daunting . . . but only if you let it be!

“Will you come to our meeting next Monday?” you might ask. “I’ll try,” they reply. Great, you think, I got my first one. You put it down as a yes.

Except it isn’t a yes. Why not follow up with, “That’s fine, but can I really count on you to be there? Yes or no?”

Many people never get there. And in failing to ask for commitments, we are showing a lack of respect for the agency of our constituents to do the work needed to make it happen. Maybe we fear rejection, or maybe even acceptance—which, after all, binds us to the person of whom we have made the ask. Either way, by failing to ask for a commitment we fail to create the tension required to elicit a clear choice. In civic mode, we are not asking people to do us a favor. We are offering those who share our concern an opportunity to do something about it. Their commitment matters.

The key is not in making an *easy* ask but rather in making a *valuable* ask. Some of us believe that the easier the ask, the lower the cost, the more likely the commitment. Is that really the basis on which you decide to what to commit? Here’s my one dollar a year, which will solve child poverty. Really? The reality is that we commit—or want to commit—because it’s valuable. I am more likely to commit if I believe my contribution will really make a difference, will really matter. When we try to get a commitment by making it easier to say yes, we work against ourselves and our constituents by trivializing the whole effort. Moreover, most of us really do take the commitments we make seriously—which is one reason we avoid making them.

Sometimes we hesitate to ask a committed person for a subsequent or greater commitment. We might think, for example, that if a person commits to giving money, they are less likely to volunteer their time. But it turns out that commitments generate more commitments: once a person makes their first commitment in support of a particular cause, they are more likely to make a bigger commitment in the future! This way of thinking confuses economic resources, which deplete with use, and moral resources, which grow with use.

Social psychologists rely on consistency theory to explain this phenomenon: once we commit, as by signing a pledge, we are more likely to make future choices that are consistent with that one.⁴ In other words, someone who signs a petition is more likely to volunteer or give money, and vice versa.

In our grape boycott, you could start by signing a pledge not to buy grapes, then you could volunteer for a shift on a picket line, then you could volunteer to captain a picket line, then you could commit to serving on a local boycott committee . . . all the way up to quitting your job or dropping out of school and joining us full time.

Successful organizing campaigns often incorporate actions that require different levels of commitment, offering people multiple entry points of engagement. The beauty of the grape boycott was that it was an action in which everyone—from a person who shunned grapes in a Florida supermarket to a student who dropped out of school to come to work full time for the UFW, and everything in between—could play a part. At one point in 1975, pollster Lou Harris found that 12 percent of the American public, some 17 million people, were boycotting grapes. The wider the opportunity to contribute, the wider the possible participation, and the more widely distributed the responsibility—and credit—for success. When many people can contribute to the effort, they all can share in its success. It is their victory. This, in turn, creates motivation and a sense of entitlement that facilitates accountability.

There is also a big difference between securing commitments and sharing information as discussed earlier. Broadcasting word of a meeting on social media and asking people for a commitment to attend are not the same thing. Unless organizers and volunteers ask for and obtain commitments to attend—in writing if possible—meeting attendance will depend on chance. This is challenging because we fear rejection, and we fear placing others under obligation because it obliges us as well. Whatever the reasons, it takes courage, training, and dedication to develop a team of leaders who are not afraid to ask for and get commitments. Without this, the action will always remain just a little out of reach.

Finally, there can be a big difference between making commitments and keeping them (unless they were not real commitments in the first place). Many of us say we will be there by 10:00 but instead arrive at 10:15. We say we'll get something done by Thursday but don't finish it until Friday. When we break commitments, even in small ways, the commitment itself begins to mean less for us and for others who are counting on us. Within an organization, failure to honor commitments has an exponentially negative effect. If commitment stops meaning very much for me, when I commit to organizing two house meetings per week with fifteen people at each, am I really going to think that I'll be able to? And if I don't think I can, how hard will

I work toward this goal? Leaders, in other words, need to create a culture of commitment.

Motivation

As an organizer, I had learned certain dos and don'ts of keeping volunteers motivated in the process of mobilizing and sustaining voter registration and petition drives and managing canvassing operations and phone banks. Training, having clear goals, and visible counting helped, as did a little friendly competition.

But I didn't really get it until I was studying with the late Richard Hackman, the distinguished scholar of organizational behavior. Richard introduced me to motivational task design, or how to design tasks so that the motivation to do them well, improve at doing them, and stick with doing them comes from within rather than from extrinsic rewards, like pay, pats on the head, cookies, or medals. Motivational task design entails structuring the work so it becomes intrinsically motivational for those doing it.⁵ These ideas were not totally new to me, but this clear articulation of how they interacted with each other enabled me to perform them with craft, intentionality, and excellence. I was surprised to find that the private sector had a far better understanding of how to design inherently motivational work, while sectors that depend on values motivated volunteers remained ignorant. Values-based leaders too often regarded routine tasks as "shit work," assigned it to those of lowest status, and turned them into tests of commitment rather than opportunities for leadership development.

Tasks designed to yield intrinsic rewards are inherently satisfying and produce greater motivation in the form of initiative, learning, and commitment than tasks that only yield recognition, financial, or status rewards.⁶ Actions built around tasks that produce greater motivation will create the following experiences for participants:

- **Experienced meaningfulness:** The task is important in the overall scheme of things.
- **Experienced responsibility:** How well the task gets done is up to me.
- **Understood results:** I can see whether I'm doing the work well as I'm doing it.

Organizers can create this experience for participants by designing tasks to have the following characteristics:

- **Task significance:** Does the person experience the significance of the task in terms of its contribution to a valued impact on the world? Does the task matter?
- **Task identity:** Is the person's own contribution, from start to finish, clear in the final result?
- **Skill variety:** Does the task engage a variety of the person's skills, including heart, hands, and head?
- **Autonomy:** Does the person have the space to make competent choices about how to do the work?
- **Feedback:** Are the results visible to the person performing the task as they perform it?

Designing tasks around these characteristics will create the desired psychological states in participants, which leads to positive outcomes for participants and results in positive outcomes for the campaign (Figure 5.3).



Figure 5.3 Motivational Task Design. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

To see how you put this skill into practice, consider two different ways that you might design a phone bank. It's ten days before an election and early voting has begun. The campaign is trying to nail down voting commitments from less likely voters who are nonetheless believed to be likely to support the campaign's candidate, ballot measure, or cause, if they voted. Given the number of votes needed to win, the number of votes counted, and the number needed to make up the deficit, the goal for this phone bank is to get one thousand commitments in the next four hours. Given the number of volunteers, any given caller would need to obtain at least fifty commitments from a particular part of the city. Molly is the phone bank coordinator, and Ashley is the volunteer.

Scenario 1

Ashley arrives, and Molly greets her volunteer. "Ashley? Thank you so much for volunteering. We need your help. Here's a packet that has all the information: a list of voters, a script, and a way to record results. You can mark their response directly on the list. Just find a spot over there and get started. Good luck. Oh yes, there's some coffee and cookies over there, and the rest room is around that corner. All set?"

Ashley takes her seat, reviews the materials for about ten minutes, and begins to call.

After two hours pass, Ashley puts her phone down and goes up to Molly, telling her, "Sorry, but I have to go. Here's the packet."

Molly replies, "Thanks so much for your help. Just toss the packet over there in the corner with the others. See you next time."

Scenario 2

Ashley arrives. Molly welcomes her: "Thank you, Ashley (it's Ashley, right?). I'm Molly. Thanks so much for volunteering, especially for this shift. I know I don't have to remind you of why winning this vote matters so much for all of us!" She asks why the campaign is so important to Ashley and listens to her answer. Assuming she says anything remotely appropriate, Molly reinforces her response, "Yep. That makes a lot of sense."

After this conversation, Molly provides some background: "We've only got ten days until the polls close, but early voting has already begun. We think we only need another ten thousand votes we can count on. So, we need to nail down five hundred of them here in Springfield tonight. We've assigned you this very important part of town. If you can nail down fifty commits to vote

early tonight, with everyone else's work, we should be able to make it. Are you up for that?"

After waiting for a response, Molly moves into the nitty-gritty and hands Ashley a packet. "Can you find the list? Great!" She runs through how it works, consistently asking Ashley to find the relevant information and following up to see if she has questions. Instead of a formal script, she invites Ashley to speak naturally. "Remember, the first thing on the call is to introduce yourself, ask how the voter is doing, respond. Then get to talking points. The idea's not just to read them but to have a conversation about them." When the script does matter, she emphasizes it: "When you're ready comes the ask. Would you read what it says there? Great! That's good. So, when you get your 'yes' click on this link, share anything special, and then you'll be ready to move on."

Molly then directs Ashley to a specific area, "the spot we've reserved for you." She points to the coffee, the cookies, and the restroom. She leaves Ashley, saying, "Thanks, I'll check in in about 30 minutes to see how it's going. And we'll take a break in about 90 minutes, so we get a little rest and see what we've been learning before we get back on the phones. All set? Good luck!"

Molly checks on Ashley after 30 minutes, answers a few questions, asks what she's learning, and notes how well she's done. Over the break, Molly leads a check-in on the numbers and adjusts the plan depending on who's setting an example and who needs support.

At the end of the shift, Molly calls everyone together: "How about a big round of applause for all the good work? Take a look at how we did! Woo! Hoo! We're just two over our goal! Wait a second. Ashley, you got ten. That's three more than anyone else. How'd you do it?" They continue to discuss what worked, what didn't, and what they could do differently.

Molly ends the shift with an invitation to the group: "Before you go, you can see where we need to be, how much we can do if we all show up, so who can commit to tomorrow night? And who will you bring?" Commitments secured, she thanks them and wishes them a good night. "We'll see eight of you again tomorrow! On to victory!!"

* * *

Now let's apply our evaluative criteria on a 1 to 5 scale (see Table 5.1).

In this—admittedly exaggerated—case we can see a clear difference in motivational task design. While most real-life cases would likely generate a score somewhere between these extremes of 5 and 25, the point is that you can use these criteria to evaluate your current practice and pinpoint areas for improvement.

Table 5.1 Evaluation of Task Design Scenarios

Scenario 1			Scenario 2	
Criteria	Characteristic	Score	Characteristic	Score
Task Significance	No context provided. No training.	1	Touched on all key points, goals, and impact; listened; trained.	5
Task Identity	Ashley's interests not recognized at the beginning or end. No interest displayed in her learning. No connection to the final result.	1	Ashley recognized. Clear goal connected to a larger goal, with focus on her preparation. Midpoint check-in; final individual and group recognition.	5
Skill Variety	Read the script, make the call, note the response.	1	Interact with voters, interpret talking points, respond to learning.	5
Autonomy	None	1	Invitation to structure calls based on caller's judgment. Creativity.	5
Feedback	If feedback was available, the caller did not know it.	1	Call progress digitally tracked, visible on ongoing basis, and reviewed after 30 minutes and at the end.	5
Total Score:		5		25

Using these criteria as a diagnostic, we can evaluate participant tasks to determine how motivational they are, redesign them to make them more motivational, and construct them to create a leadership ladder, an opportunity for people to earn greater responsibilities. In these examples, we can clearly see that if the task is designed properly, the phone bank leader can easily identify who's doing well and could possibly do more. Perhaps this volunteer could become a phone bank trainer, a coach, a coordinator, the director of the coordinators, and so on. Any task, properly designed, is an entry point to leadership.

Commitment: The Four Cs

One approach organizers take to getting commitments is called the four Cs: connect, context, commitment, and catapult (Figure 5.4).

Connect. Identify yourself and why you're doing what you're doing and let them know why you're asking them to help. This can be done with a few words.

Context. Be specific about the urgency of the challenge, the plausibility of the hope, and why they matter in achieving a goal about which they care. This can be a story of now.

Commitment. Make the ask as specific as you can to the person you are trying to mobilize. Ask explicitly if you can count on them to do what you're asking. Be very specific about the date, time, and place. Do not be shy. Be certain. And be joyful (if appropriate).

You can use phrases like, "Can we count on you to join us in _____?" Or "Will you join me in doing _____?" Listen carefully to their response.

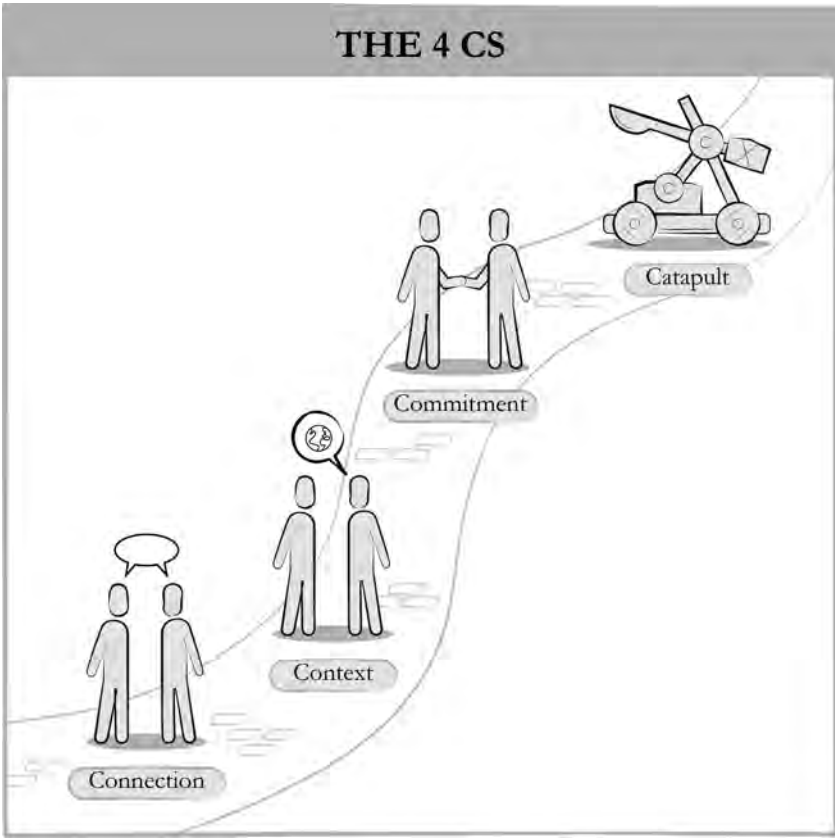


Figure 5.4 The 4 Cs. Source: Steve Downer of the Difference

If they say, “Yes! Definitely!” confirm the details. If they say, “Maybe,” ask what questions they have and how you can follow up. If they decline, ask why, and give them your contact information in case they change their mind.

Catapult. If someone says yes, then give them the respect of having real work and real responsibility and confirm they have a real plan to get there. You might ask, for example, whether they can bring something to the event (food, posters, etc.), or you might ask them to commit to bringing two people with them. Be sure to ask how the person plans on getting to the event—people with plans are much more likely to attend!⁷

To secure the participation of many people, we must delegate the responsibility of securing these commitments to a wide range of leaders or potential leaders. Yet one of the greatest hurdles novice organizers face is finding the courage to ask others explicitly for commitment and to recognize that a no is sometimes better than a maybe. Organizing, after all, is about challenging people to find the courage to make choices consistent with their values. Mobilizing participation through incentives or paying people to volunteer doesn’t do this.

Commitments are also made now, or not at all. When you ask someone if they can be at a meeting at 7:00 p.m., and they say yes, get their name and number then and follow up with a reminder call. “I’ll try,” “I’ll do my best,” and “Maybe I’ll be there” don’t count as commitments. The genuine commitments we secure in the moment, then, become an indicator of the outcome we will achieve.

Measurement as Learning: Evidence-Based Organizing

Action must be linked to specific, measurable outcomes with real deadlines. Without clear outcomes, we can evaluate neither success nor failure. If we can’t evaluate success or failure, we can’t learn for the next time. The absence of clear metrics is one reason volunteer-based work can be perceived as flaky, not reliable, leading people to think that the only way to make the work reliable is to pay for it. After all, they say, “you can’t fire volunteers” (except you can) or “you have to settle for what you get” (except you don’t). Any serious organizing effort will have to confront this reality if it intends to do real work in the world.

Election campaigns are easier to quantify, in that we must secure a specific number of votes to win. But even in this setting, campaigns often avoid committing to intermediate outcomes. One of the main reasons we may avoid committing to specific outcomes is a fear that failure to reach that goal will diminish the motivation needed to sustain the movement. The cost of avoiding this risk, however, is not only strategic but is also motivational. One of the most important leadership challenges is learning to handle losing. A campaign loss requires narrative interpretation: Does the setback contaminate the enterprise, or does it provide an opportunity for redemption?

Measuring outcomes allows a group to assess, concretely, what is happening and to learn how to improve upon it in what can be a kind of “campaign audit.” Assessment allows a group to calculate how it is doing over the course of time. Have we secured as many votes as we had planned to secure at this point in our work? This enables a comparison of one’s own outcomes with those of the opposition, or of previous efforts. If we continue at this rate, will we be victorious? What must we do to win? These sorts of comparisons, in turn, allow a group to continue or to alter its course to ensure victory.

Measurement also allows us to learn by making visible who among us is succeeding, who is failing, and why. Who persuaded more people to sign up? Who was not able to persuade as many? What can we learn from this comparison? In other words, how can every organizer perform at the level of the most successful ones?

Similarly, having concrete outcomes allows a group to focus clearly on the specific actions that it must take to produce these outcomes and, in turn, which activities unrelated to the outcome can be eliminated. Without measurable outcome goals, a group can easily lose focus and direction.

Unfortunately, metrics can also be used to assert control, as when a manager decides to fire anyone in the bottom 10 percent, or when an organization makes public statements about who is or isn’t good enough. This type of punitive metrics often measures actions that are countable, rather than actions that are valuable. We see this frequently when funders insist on measuring the number of something (phone calls, voter contacts) as a proxy for something else (power, effectiveness).

It is also the case that easily quantifiable measures available digitally can become a kind of ersatz way of measuring outcomes—hyper-analyzed, targeted models—but decoupled from support of the actual ways in which people work with other people.

Total transparency about the use of metrics helps counter the suspicion that numbers are being used to exert control. It’s just as important that the

constituency sees the numbers being used. For example, Joe's ratio of calls to commitments is very good, especially when compared to Sam's. "So, Joe, describe what you're doing: is it the list, the neighborhood, your pitch, do they already know you? And Sam, describe what you're doing. Oh . . . you haven't gotten the training on how to get commits? Joe, would you give Sam some coaching?" Confronting the reality, probing at what it means, seeing what works and what doesn't, and distancing it from any form of judgment and reprimand can make everyone a learner and a teacher.

Creating measurable outcomes allows us to take control of meeting our goals. Having measurable outcomes—turning out 25,000 votes, for example—lets us focus on something we can control. It becomes a basis for evaluation as well as for learning. Were 25,000 votes in fact enough, as we thought? Or did the other candidate win despite our turning out 25,000? In the future, what should our goal be?

As we discussed in the chapter on strategy, because goals are often embedded within goals, we need to measure our progress on each. For example, in 1990 I worked on the California "Big Green" initiative. To win we would need to identify, recruit, and turn out 75,000 committed voters who only occasionally vote. We would need to kick off the campaign, build the infrastructure to get the job done, and of course turn out these voters on election day.

Kickoffs: On *Saturday, October 20*, mobilize 500 people for seven kickoffs across the state.

Organizing Peak: By *November 2*, recruit, train and deploy 1,000 Precinct Leaders to contact 300,000 occasional voters to commit at least 150,000 "green" voters among them.

Election Day: On *November 6*, turn out 75,000 additional "Big Green" voters to the polls.

Of course, each of these outcome goals had several layers of outcome goals embedded within them. For example, how many people needed to be recruited to help turn out the 500 people on October 20? How many of those 500 people needed to assume leadership roles to recruit precinct leaders? How many hours did each of the 1,000 precinct leaders need to work every day to identify their voters?

In the UFW grape boycott, we learned to count grape carloads arriving in a city to evaluate the effectiveness of our local boycott organizing. We learned from asking why one city was more responsive than another. We learned that

the effect of the boycott was less to reduce overall grape shipments than it was to reconfigure the market by driving prices down, redirecting grapes, for example, from New York to Dallas. Within each city, we counted the number of customers turned away from a supermarket to calculate the cost we had imposed. This enabled local picket captains, organizers, coordinators, and project directors to experience the impact of their work (or lack of it), learn from it, and strategize ways in which they could become more effective from the bottom up.

In the Obama campaign, we counted the number of volunteers participating in our activities, how many activities were conducted, and who was responsible for which outcome. The intent, however, was not control but learning. Prior to the general election, the Ohio and Pennsylvania teams competed in identifying voters committed to vote for Obama: Barack cheered one state and Michelle cheered on the other.

Organizing physical space to focus on outcomes can help as well—for example, the number of votes secured through phone calls and house meetings can be displayed on a large chart that hangs in the line of sight of anyone who enters headquarters. When you walk through an organizing office, it ought to remind people of what needs to be done, what's important, what things should happen next. The place should have an orienting effect.

Without commitment to clear outcomes, post-action evaluations can't get established as a routine practice. This is routine practice in the military in the form of the After Action Report: a detailed analysis of prior action not for blame but for learning.

Post-action evaluations are a key element in creating a brave space, with the expectation that we must be learning in a regular, ongoing way.

Action in Practice: Contingency, Craft, and Consistency

Do or do not. There's no try!

—Yoda, *The Empire Strikes Back*

The world of organizing is a world of contingency—everything can go wrong. Someone forgets to unlock the hall, the sound system is missing a cable, someone forgot to order the chairs, the map got printed backward, half the flyers didn't get printed on time, someone's car has a flat tire, the date was mistranslated in the Spanish version: the list could go on and on. Any human endeavor must deal with contingency. But in a setting where inexperienced

people are trying to achieve major tasks, under the pressure of time and with fewer resources than they need—as is typical of most organizing situations—the potential for disaster is always lurking just around the corner. And much of the time, we can't do anything about it.

There are nevertheless contingencies about which we can do a great deal on which we can focus. For example, when asking someone for a specific commitment, asking them to put it in writing improves the odds they will show up. One of the most important aspects of the organizer's craft is to develop the pride of craft discipline to reduce contingencies to a minimum. In this way too structure can create space. As this approach becomes habitual, we can free ourselves to focus on the creative, the innovative, the compassionate, and the hopeful.

Although it may seem intense, the extent to which an organizer can reduce contingency to a minimum is substantial. It is also an investment in making good on time already invested. In a 1974 Bay Area organizing campaign to boycott lettuce, for example, the following is a first-person account of organizing trainer Fred Ross “lovingly” coaching organizer Larry Tramutola on the significance of each detail and the difference getting it right makes. Not unlike learning to create music, excel in athletics, or conduct experiments, this technique is not a way to harass or to blame the organizer. It is a way in which organizers can learn to make the most of their agency to show respect for the work, the people, and oneself.

Pointing to the chart and handing me a colored marker, he told me, “Write down everything you must do each day. Who are you meeting on Monday?” I went over to the butcher paper and wrote down the names and times of the three people that I was supposed to meet that day. Fred continued, “OK, now when are you calling these people to remind them that you are coming to see them?”

Remind them I was coming to see them? “I hadn't thought of that,” I told Fred. “Well, write that down,” he stated firmly. “Reminding is the essence of organizing.” He went over to [the] butcher paper and wrote in the Sunday column: “Make reminder calls to:” Then, he listed the names and phone numbers of the people I was to visit the following Monday.

The lesson continued. “What time are you calling them?” he asked, and before I could answer, he instructed me, “Now write down the time.” I did.

But he was not through with me yet. “OK, now on Monday, before you meet with them, you need to call them again, right?” Fred asked. I just nodded quietly while privately thinking that all this reminding and

writing down were a bit of overkill. It was only weeks later that I came to understand that these details, and the discipline to put them into practice, are essential to good organizing. At the time, though, I had not learned that for myself, and I certainly did not want to challenge Fred, so I said nothing.

Fred went on. “Good. Now write on the butcher paper the time that you plan to call them, so you don’t forget. It is always good to call people right before you visit them, so you don’t waste time if they are not there.”

“And by the way,” he continued, “while you are at the house of one of the people on your list, ask if you can use their phone to call your next appointment. That way they’ll see how serious you are,” he said.⁸

Of course, Fred practiced what he preached; holding himself responsible for ensuring Larry’s success, he held Larry responsible for ensuring that success in making good on their commitments. Larry recalls being coached at the end of each day by Ross:

We started every call with what I had accomplished during the day. He peppered me with probing questions that demanded thoughtful answers and accountability: “Why did you do that?” “What did you say when he said that?” The interrogation went on for two hours and often longer, as I had to report and relive my successes and failures of the day. Fred asked me one question after another, and unless I was prepared to simply hang up and walk away from what I was doing, there was no escape or relief. But I endured the torment, partly out of pride and partly because I knew Fred was teaching me invaluable lessons about the importance of follow-through and disciplined work.⁹

Good coaches know what questions to ask and know when they are not getting complete answers from those they are coaching. In different organizing situations, there are different questions that are important to ask, and different ways of recognizing when people are bullshitting.

Action in Practice: Motivation and Commitment

Balancing motivational energy and disciplined commitment can be challenging. Focus on commitment can be experienced as trying to quantify,

measure, and “control” motivation rather than as a way to turn motivational energy into the commitment, into the power to change the world. Of course, the opposite may also be the case: the expressive can be experienced as interference with the clear strategic logic of commitment. Successful social movements learn how to cultivate a culture of commitment, learning, and discipline. At our best, we learned how to do this in the UFW. But cultures of commitment and discipline, if not about learning, can become seriously abusive, especially in movements subject to charismatic and authoritarian leadership structures.

The tools of strategy—targeting, monitoring, and constantly adapting to ever-shifting realities—do not replace motivation, but they do give it real leverage. This is the challenge in so many current campaigns whose technological capacity far exceeds anything we imagined at that point in time but which is no replacement for the motivation rooted in reality. Of course, motivation without this kind of craft doesn’t get it either, any more than it did back in 1966 when I learned my first lessons about it.

Conclusion

In the introduction to this book, I introduced three measures of impact when it comes to organizing: the change (our goal), the power (our organizational capacity), and the people (leadership development). In the context of action, these measures can be used even more explicitly.

Did we accomplish the goal we set out to accomplish?

Did we pass the law, organize the union, elect the candidate, launch the cop, and so on? If we didn’t, do we know why? If we did, do we know why? Do we sustain our effectiveness by measuring visible outputs, analyzing what we see, and adapting what we do based on what we see?

When a campaign ends, one of the most common behaviors—win or lose—is to walk away without any serious learning. A commitment to craft, however, would require asking ourselves: Did we develop metrics to track our successes and failures? Or did we turn the learning over to the “professionals” whose interpretation may be a profit-making proposition?

Did we come out of the campaign with greater organizational capacity than we had at the beginning?

Did we grow stronger as an organization? Did we get better at working together? Have our people grown more powerful? Can we build on what

we learned? Or do we never want to see anyone connected with this campaign again?

Most electoral campaigns have no interest in building a sustainable organization once the election is over, no matter what the claims (unless they lose). Too often, this is also the case with many advocacy campaigns. In these campaigns as well we need to ask ourselves if we conducted the campaign with an eye to building organizational capacity, or the opposite? Yet for organizing, this outcome is arguably the most important: the transformation of a disempowered community into an empowered community, not only in the conduct of its internal affairs, but also in its ability to influence the shape of the world around it.

Did we recruit, train, and develop the leadership to take our work forward?

Did we develop new leadership motivated to learn, grow, and act? Or did we only exhaust all our old leadership?

* * *

We next turn to the ways to structure the interaction of relationship building, storytelling, strategizing, and action in our work with each other in both campaigns and organizations.